

CSS font-family Property

Coding & Web Development | Lecture 10 | By Nishant Sir — Summary Notes

1. What is font-family?

font-family is a CSS property used to define the typeface (font) used to render text on a webpage. Rather than naming a single font, it accepts a **comma-separated list of fonts** — this list is called a **font stack**.

The browser reads the list from left to right and uses the **first font that is actually installed / available** on the visitor's device. If none of the named fonts are available, it falls back to a generic family so the text is never left unstyled.

2. Example — Font Stack in Action

```
#aditya {  
  font-family: Verdana, Geneva, Tahoma, sans-serif;  
}
```

In the CSS rule above, the selector **#aditya** is given a font stack with three named fonts followed by one generic family.

3. How the Browser Resolves the Stack

Step	Font Tried	Type	What Happens
1	Verdana	Named font	Used if installed on the user's device; otherwise skipped.
2	Geneva	Named font	Tried next if Verdana is unavailable; skipped if also missing.
3	Tahoma	Named font	Tried next if both above are unavailable; skipped if missing.
4	sans-serif	Generic family	Guaranteed fallback — always supported by every browser.

■ **Key idea:** the stack acts like a priority list — the browser always tries to use the most preferred, high-quality font first, and only drops down the list when a font isn't found.

4. Why Use a Font Stack?

- **Reliability:** Not every font is installed on every device or OS, so a single-font rule risks the browser substituting an unpredictable default.
- **Cross-platform consistency:** Fonts such as Verdana or Tahoma are common on Windows but may be missing on macOS/Linux — the stack keeps the design looking close to intended on all systems.
- **Safety net with generic families:** Ending the stack with a generic family (e.g. sans-serif) guarantees text always renders in a visually similar font, even if every named font fails.
- **Designer control:** Lets developers rank fonts by preference instead of leaving font selection entirely to the browser/OS default.

5. Generic Font Family Categories

Generic Family	Description	Example Fonts
serif	Fonts with small decorative strokes/feet at the end of letters	Times New Roman, Georgia
sans-serif	Clean fonts without decorative strokes	Arial, Verdana, Helvetica
monospace	Every character occupies equal width (fixed-width)	Courier New, Consolas
cursive	Mimics handwriting / script style	Comic Sans MS, Brush Script
fantasy	Decorative, stylized display fonts	Impact, Papyrus

6. Syntax Rules to Remember

- Separate multiple font names with **commas**.
- If a font name contains a **space** (e.g. "Times New Roman"), wrap it in quotes.
- Always place a **generic family name** (sans-serif, serif, etc.) as the **last** item in the stack.
- Font names are case-insensitive, but keeping the official capitalization is good practice.

7. Quick Takeaway

■ **font-family** does not set just one font — it defines a **priority list of fonts** (a font stack). This ensures a webpage's text always has a working fallback and never breaks visually, even if the visitor's device is missing your preferred font.